Dozens quarantined after researcher at Russian plague laboratory dies of ‘unknown’ infection

Dozens of people were reported to be in isolation after a Russian laboratory worker at an institute dedicated to studying the plague and other infectious diseases died of an undisclosed illness.

The researcher, a 28-year-old female laboratory technician at the Irkutsk Research Anti-Plague Institute of Siberia, in the town of Shelekhov, died after being diagnosed with a pneumonia of “unknown” origin, according to Rospotrebnadzor, the Russian agency that handles infectious disease.

US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said Tuesday that Russia should share more information about the circumstances of the researcher’s death.

“I think it’s incumbent upon Russia to obviously share more information with the world,” he said. “Maybe it’s bigger than we thought. We don’t know, but I think it would be reckless at this moment, given the limited information we still have, to speculate.”

“We’re watching it very closely, hour by hour,” he added.

Rospotrebnadzor has played down the link between the death of the researcher — named in local media as Darya Shipilova — and her work.

“No micro-organisms associated with the employee’s professional duties were detected in samples taken from the patient,” it asserted, adding that the “epidemiological situation” in the region was stable.

Nevertheless, the agency’s head, Anna Popova, traveled to Irkutsk on Friday, according to the local governor, Igor Kobzev, for what he described as an extraordinary meeting of the regional anti-epidemic commission.

The meeting was in connection with a “suspected case of a particularly dangerous infection affecting a resident of the region,” Kobzev said on Telegram.

Reached by phone on Monday, the institute where the researcher worked told CNN it was not commenting on the incident.

Speaking on Monday, President Donald Trump said the US would be willing to help. “Anybody that has that kind of a problem, we’re always willing to help,” Trump told reporters before departing the White House for Nebraska. “I hate to see them having it,” Trump added. “It’s a rough disease.”

Anti-epidemic measures

Regional authorities are implementing a “comprehensive set of anti-epidemic measures,” according to Maxim Modin, the mayor of the Shelekhovsky district in eastern Russia, near the Mongolian border.

The inpatient facility at the hospital where the worker was treated has been placed under quarantine, and several departments have stopped discharging or admitting patients, Modin said. Other hospitals in the region have also been closed, according to local media reports.

Irkutsk authorities also cancelled the annual community clean-up event that was scheduled for the weekend — a decision local media linked to the incident.

The woman’s death was confirmed by officials last week.

Ekaterina, a resident of Shekelov, told CNN on Monday that there were no visible changes in the city, but locals were anxious. “My acquaintances are slightly panicking,” she said.

Another resident, who wished to remain anonymous, said he was “shocked” by the news.

Unofficial reports, including by the independent regional news outlet Liudi Baikala, have said that nearly 200 people are under observation.

Several people who had made contact with the researcher have been diagnosed with Covid-19 and rhinovirus, the most frequent cause of the common cold, Rospotrebnadzor said, state news agency TASS reported on Monday.

The Kremlin has urged people only to trust news coming from official channels.

“One should rely on official statements from Rospotrebnadzor rather than listening to various rumors and speculation,” Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Monday.

WHO says public health risk “low”

The World Health Organization told CNN it was in contact with the Russian health authorities to “verify the event, its circumstances, the laboratory tests underway, and their results.”

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“Based on unofficial information available, the public health risk to the general population appears to be low,” it said.

Despite such reassurances, several countries in the region have put in place safeguarding measures.

Kazakhstan's Ministry of Health said that while the risk was "very low", the situation was being monitored and "sanitary and quarantine controls were implemented at state border crossing points."

Uzbekistan said it "increased the readiness" of relevant authorities to deal with highly infectious diseases. Kyrgyzstan, which does not share a land border with Russia is some 1,500 miles from Irkutsk, announced Monday it was introducing quarantine controls at state border crossing points.

A virologist in Siberia, Alexander Chepurnov, told CNN that the strict protocols being followed were designed to prevent onward spread.

"After any suspected exposure, staff are instructed to immediately report it, decontaminate, undergo medical assessment and be isolated in a separate dedicated facility for however long they might be infectious," Chepirnov said.

Deadly but not easily transmitted

Angela Rassmussen, a virologist at the Vaccine and Infectious Disease Organization, told CNN that while pneumonic plague is deadly, it is not very transmissible and one would have to be exposed to a high bacterial load to become sick.

In that sense, it is unlike respiratory illnesses such as COVID, she said.

There is endemic plague among wildlife in parts of Siberia, Rassmussen added.

According to its website, the Anti-Plague Institute employs around 95 researchers and is a major public health facility responsible for monitoring and preventing outbreaks of high-risk bacterial and viral infections across Siberia and Russia's Far East.

The head of the neighboring republic of Buryatia, Alexei Tsydenov, said earlier that the employee died "possibly from the plague," but noted there had been no outbreak of the disease in his region.

Pneumonic plague is one of three types of plagues that are caused by the bacterium Yersinia pestis.

The other two types typically spread from contact with infected fleas, animals or infected tissues.

An aluminum plant near the laboratory instructed staff to wear masks as a precautionary measure. The director of Irkutsk Aluminum Plant, Artem Fominikh, noted “conflicting reports” were circulating and called for calm

The infection in the Irkutsk region is “most likely not the plague, but even if confirmed, there will be no spread of this disease,” a former head of Rospotrebnadzor, Gennady Onishchenko, said on Friday.

Onishchenko told TASS that the onset of cold weather would likely prevent transmission.

Patients with pneumonic plague develop fever, headache, weakness and and “a rapidly developing pneumonia with shortness of breath, chest pain, cough, and sometimes bloody or watery mucous,” according to the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC).

The World Health Organization notes that the plague has a high fatality rate, but is also easily treated with antibiotics if caught early.